

1206 CHINGGIS KHAN FOUNDS THE MONGOL EMPIRE

Early in the 13th century, a warrior called Temujin (c. 1162-1227) united all the nomadic Mongolian and Tatar tribes of the Asian steppe under his rule. Adopting the name Chinggis Khan ("ruler of the world"), he sent the steppe horsemen on campaigns of conquest. No army could resist them. By the time of his death, the Mongols controlled an empire stretching from the Pacific coast to the Caspian Sea.

▷ Chinggis Khan in combat in a miniature from *Jami' al-tawarikh*, c. 1430



1200

1206 The Delhi Sultanate,
a Muslim state in north India,
is founded by Qutb-ud-Din
Aybak (r. 1206-10)

**1209 The pope
proclaims a crusade**
against Albigensian heretics
in southern France

1204 SACK OF CONSTANTINOPLE

The Fourth Crusade, proclaimed by Pope Innocent III, degenerated into a squalid mercenary enterprise. Instead of fighting Muslims in Egypt, the crusaders looted the wealthy Christian Byzantine capital, Constantinople. The Byzantine Empire was restored but never fully recovered its territory or wealth.



△ Mosaic floor showing a scene from the Fourth Crusade

1209 ST FRANCIS CREATES THE FRANCISCAN ORDER

Francis of Assisi, son of an Italian merchant, adopted a life of poverty after a series of religious visions. In 1209, he was authorized by Pope Innocent III to found an order of monks who would wander the world, begging for alms and preaching. The Franciscan Order grew rapidly in reaction against the wealth and corruption of the medieval Catholic Church.



△ Saint Francis of Assisi with Angels, Sandro Botticelli, c. 1475